ALMOST-RANA AND ALSO-RAN

If it's 'Rajasthan', surely the rajas who once ruled the rugged *dungars* can't be out of the game. But here we have two worthies who lost their kingdom, in different ways. The royal apparition is Vishvaraj Singh Mewar of, well, Mewar. He will be riding out to Nathdwara—not far from the turmeric-coloured grass of Haldighati—as the saffron chevalier. But unlike his legendary forebear, Maharana Pratap, he won't be battling the mighty Mughal army. Duelling with him in the winter sun will be the much less alarming figure of assembly speaker C.P. Joshi—the bespectacled Congress veteran who almost became CM in 2008 but fluffed his tryst with destiny by losing an election by one vote.

Not to be confused with the other C.P. Joshi—the young state BJP chief—our 73-year-old Joshi is a Nathdwara native. But Vishvaraj could well deem it his divine right to contest from Nathdwara too. The charming temple town is the seat of Shrinathji, a form of Krishna, but not far down the road resides Shiva himself, as Eklingji, tutelary deity-king of Mewar in whose name the Maharanas reigned. In 1984, that line had passed down to Vishvaraj's father, Mahendra.

Formal kingship is long gone, but the name still has cachet in the local psyche. Mahendra himself was the BJP MP from Chittorgarh in 1989 but, like many maharanas in history, switched sides. In the 1991 Lok Sabha poll, he fought under the Congress flag, only to lose to the BJP's Jaswant Singh. In 1996, he moved to Bhilwara, but lost again. Some say the Rajputs haven't forgiven him for abandoning Chittorgarh. He insists he left because of "L.K. Advani's communal rath yatra". Real reason: the BJP didn't back him in his dispute with younger brother Arvind Singh Mewar for the titular crown and the properties. Most of it remains with Arvind, whose son Lakshyaraj is said to be eyeing a political career too. Vishvaraj may have stolen a march over him by going with the BJP, though local leaders haven't warmed to him yet. One vote too cool, Joshi will be hoping. ■



Illustrations by SIDDHANT JUMDE



ONCE SUSPENDED, ALWAYS ANIMATED

The BJP seems to have 'forgiven' Thakur Raja Singh, its lone MLA from Telangana, whom it had suspended in August 2022 for his derogatory remarks against Muslims and Prophet Mohammed in a video after controversy erupted over stand-up comic Munawar Faruqui's show in Hyderabad. Revoking the suspension, the party is fielding him again from the Goshamahal constituency from where he has won twice. Singh,